

friends. This allows friends in the network to share information easily. Whrrl also integrates with Twitter, a social networking platform for people to communicate with their friends. One key limitation of Whirrl is that it works only on GPS-enabled mobile phones.

Whereabouts is a similar application, which was primarily targetted at family members who need to track each other. Worrying parents can track the location of their kids on a real-time basis. Whereabouts also provides integration with Facebook, making it an extended social networking system.

Micro BTS (www.microtechnologies.net) is a buddy tracking system offered by Micro Technologies in India. The system is fairly simple to use, but is not free.

An upcoming system, known as Trackut (www.trackut.com) takes these applications to newer dimensions. Trackut offers all the options of a buddy-tracking system not only on GPS-enabled mobile phones, but it works on non-GPS phones also. Moreover, Trackut is an operator-independent service, which makes it versatile, and it can be used virtually anywhere in the world. Fundamentally, Trackut is a location-based information streaming system, which can help users create location-oriented groups and share information with friends.

In addition to offering basic buddy tracking service, Trackut provides multi-channel location-based streaming. A Trackut user can record any event, describe it, tag it and share it with friends. The event capture can be real-time, using the phone to record and share it with the network. The captured story could be about a restaurant you liked, a party where you had fun, or could be temporal such as a traffic jam you are stuck in. Trackut manages these and streams them to the right audience when they are near the locations where these events occurred.

Such an application opens up possibilities to do many things on a convergent platform. When a movie feed is converged with such application, you can drive into any area and find out which one of the closest cinema hall is running a movie of your choice. An alumni group may choose to join the network and the members can share their office and home locations with peers.

The possibilities are endless. However, Trackut is in evolution process and the interface needs some upgrade. It's a promising application and should mature soon.

An application of special interest is got-2 Task Management (www.gwhizmobile.com). This application takes simple electronic task lists to the next level. A traditional task list uses date and time as an event to trigger an alert, whereas got-2 Task Management adds a new dimension (location) to trigger an alert. The way it works is that whenever you create a task, in addition to

entering the due date/time, you also specify the location, where the task can be performed. For example, if you add a task for dry-cleaning, you also provide the address for the dry-cleaner. Whenever, you drive into the same areas as the dry-cleaner, an alert for this task will come up on your phone screen. The best part is, got-2 Task Management integrates with Microsoft Outlook and Google Calendar, making it simple to synchronise with your usual task list.

While these platforms open up new possibilities of information exchange, they also bring about significant risks and challenges.



got-2 Task Management

For example, the buddy tracking systems are considered a serious privacy invader, limiting its use to close family members only. Although most applications allow you to enable or disable location sharing, it can be cumbersome to manage it. Another drawback is that these systems eat a lot of battery power since they would require the GPS antenna to remain switched on whenever you use them. The battery consumption increases if you are inside a building or around tall buildings. The third big disadvantage is the cost of data transfer. Since all these systems use GPRS or an equivalent method to communicate, there is a significant flow of data from the mobile phone. If one is not on an unlimited data plan, these systems can punch a big hole in your pocket.

All said and done, these are great tools and can make your phone do multiple things. The advice is to use them cautiously, keep a charger handy and switch to an unlimited data plan before you start using them! ☑

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GPS-enabled phone Buying tips

If GPS is one of the key requirements, it may be a good idea to consider the following aspects before choosing a phone.

GPS v/s A-GPS

Standard GPS requires a line of sight connection with at least three GPS satellites to find the exact location. Moreover, the satellite feed should be available for 30 seconds to a couple of minutes before the GPS can provide exact coordinates. This can lead to significant problems if the user is surrounded with tall buildings, trees or is indoors. Also, a GPS has to perform complex mathematical calculations using triangulation techniques to determine the position based on the satellite signals. Therefore, the start-up time for any GPS-based application can be frustrating. This problem can be solved by using an advanced technology called A-GPS or Assisted GPS. In the case of A-GPS, the GPS unit contacts an intermediary called assistance server, which helps determine the location of the device much faster. The assistance server can use the cell-phone tower information to start the computation process and also performs complex mathematical computations on a much faster processor. This provides following benefits:

- Device location is determined much faster
- Location can be acquired even when there is no continuous satellite signal available
- Device has to perform less computation leading to less battery consumption

These features result in great benefits to cell phone GPS systems where battery conservation is an important consideration and one may have to use a navigation system even while talking on phone.

However, A-GPS requires an active data connection and if one is not on an unlimited data plan, its usage can lead to increased phone bills.

Display

Since GPS-enabled phones will be invariably used for navigation assistance, it's important that the screen size is reasonably large to enable easy

viewing of maps and driving directions. Higher screen resolution can add to enhanced experience. Hence, compare the display resolution before finalising your phone. Another good feature to look for should be ambient light adjustment. Many cell phone displays can increase or decrease display brightness depending on ambient lighting conditions. This is very useful when one is walking in bright sunny outdoors.

Mounting

If the objective is to make your phone double up as vehicle navigation system, it will be a good idea to buy a phone, which comes with accessories to mount it on a flat surface. This can be very handy if you use it in your car. One should avoid flip-phones because they are not very useful when it comes to using them as navigation systems.

Battery

Needless to say, GPS antennas and overlaid applications can be a big drain on battery. It will be good to have your phone with enough battery when you need to make that late evening emergency call. Phones with external charging accessories can be a better deal.

Memory

Many GPS applications will require on-device storage of static or cache data. The bigger the storage, the better it is. Most devices provide an option to enhance memory through add-on media cards. However, a device with in-built memory may offer faster response compared to the one using external storage.

Speaker

Most navigation applications offer voice prompts for driving directions. The louder the phone speaker, the easier it is to follow the instructions. There is no easy measure to compare speaker quality, but phones with dual speakers offer better capability. It may be a good idea to try the speaker out before buying an expensive phone.

